



U.S. shared intelligence with Syria's new leaders

Countries have mutual interest in preventing Islamic State resurgence

BY WARREN P. STROBEL,
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AND MISSY RYAN

The United States has shared secret intelligence on threats from the Islamic State with the new government in Syria, which is itself run by leaders of a militant group long considered by Washington to be a terrorist organization, according to multiple current and former U.S. officials familiar with the exchanges.

In at least one case, the U.S. intelligence helped thwart an Islamic State plot to attack a religious shrine outside Damascus earlier this month, according to the officials.

The back channel with Hay'at Tahrir al-Sham, which overthrew former president Bashar al-Assad's regime last month, reflects rising U.S. alarm that the Islamic State could mount a resurgence as Syria's new leaders try to consolidate control.

The intelligence sharing is driven by a mutual interest in preventing such a comeback and does not reflect a full embrace of HTS, which remains a designated terrorist organization, officials said.

"It's the right, prudent and appropriate thing to do, given that there was credible, specific information [about Islamic State threats], and coupled with our efforts to cultivate a relationship with these guys," said one former U.S. official, who, like others interviewed, spoke on the condition of anonymity because of the matter's sensitivity.

In the chaotic days after the fall of Assad, the Biden administration began to engage cautiously with HTS and its leader, Ahmed al-Sharaa, the de facto head of state in Damascus who was formerly known by his nom de guerre, Abu Mohammed al-Jolani. Sharaa has attempted to signal moderation, reaching out to world leaders and pledging not to persecute Syria's numerous religious minorities.

It is unclear what policy President Donald Trump will

SEE SYRIA ON A12

E.U. nations pivot: A deal is near on easing Syria sanctions. **A12**

Hegseth confirmed as Pentagon chief



JABIN BOTSFORD/THE WASHINGTON POST

President Donald Trump and first lady Melania Trump on Friday. The president's rhetoric did not appear to reflect a well-honed plan.

On disaster tour, Trump proposes ditching FEMA

BY CAT ZAKRZEWSKI,
MATT VISER,
BRADY DENNIS
AND MAEVE RESTON

SWANNANOVA, N.C. — President Donald Trump, on a tour of two states reeling in recent months from hurricanes and wildfires, pledged Friday to upend how the

country has responded for decades to natural disasters by saying he wants to eliminate FEMA and threatening to withhold federal assistance to California unless it passes a new voter ID law.

"I think we're going to recommend that FEMA go away," Trump said, suggesting that states take the lead in responding to disasters

and then get reimbursed a percentage of their costs from the federal government.

Rather than mobilizing federal officials who specialize in responding to disasters nationwide, he said, individual governors

Slowdown: Trump's actions have impeded business of governing. **B1**

would be responsible for overseeing disaster responses in their respective states.

"I'd like to see the states take care of disasters," he said. "Let the state take care of the tornadoes and the hurricanes and all the other things that happen. I think you're going to find it a lot less

SEE FEMA ON A4

Pick to head budget office aims to upend Washington

BY TONY ROMM
AND JEFF STEIN

Even before he takes the reins at the White House budget office, Russell Vought has started trying to remake Washington.

He has promised to pursue stark spending cuts, and he's signaled support for wresting some powers of the purse away from Congress. He's proposed vast changes to Medicaid and other safety-net programs, and

he's redoubled his commitment to purging the federal workforce, triggering a quiet, early exodus of career civil servants.

The fate of Vought's agenda ultimately rests with the Senate, where lawmakers are expected to confirm the 48-year-old conservative hawk as the next director of the Office of Management and Budget. But Vought's ideas have already captured the nation's capital and shaped some of

SEE VOUGHT ON A5

Pledged deportation sweeps underway, jolting U.S. cities

This article is by Maria Sacchetti, Nick Miroff, Dan Rosenzweig-Ziff and Teo Arnus

The deportation blitz President Donald Trump promised on the campaign trail kicked off in U.S. cities this week, delighting many of his supporters and jolting communities where immigration officers appeared — or whose arrival

Analysis: How a mass deportation campaign might unfold. **A6**

was merely rumored, sending a chill nonetheless.

Trump's executive orders have given immigration officers extraordinary new powers to cast a wider net and fast-track deportations. The president has scrapped restrictions that kept "sensitive" locations like churches and schools off-limits for immigration officers. Social media posts and school mailing lists have lit up with possible officer sightings, in

SEE DEPORTATIONS ON A8

VANCE STEPS IN FOR TIEBREAKING VOTE

For Trump, a whirlwind week of sweeping change

BY ABIGAIL HAUSLOHNER,
LIZ GOODWIN
AND MERYL KORNFIELD

The Senate on Friday confirmed President Donald Trump's nomination of Pete Hegseth, a former Fox News personality, to become the country's next defense secretary.

The appointment of Hegseth, a Trump loyalist who has called for a "frontal assault" to rid the Pentagon of what he's said is a leftist ideology, marks a dramatic political shift in the United States' national security policy and leadership.

Hegseth secured his post Friday night in a vote of 51-50, after Vice President JD Vance cast the tiebreaking vote. It marks the second time in U.S. history that a vice president's vote was necessary to confirm a Cabinet official, and Republicans applauded as Vance entered the chamber.

Three Republicans, Sens. Lisa Murkowski (Alaska), Susan Collins (Maine) and Mitch McConnell (Kentucky) joined the chamber's Democrats and independents in opposing Hegseth, following a heated confirmation process that centered on allegations of alcohol abuse, sexual misconduct and financial mismanagement. Hegseth steadily and vigorously denied any wrongdoing.

Trump had worried aloud to reporters earlier on Friday that Hegseth might not have the votes to get confirmed amid speculation that McConnell and Sen. Thom Tillis (North Carolina) might vote against his nominee. Tillis, who had told reporters he

SEE HEGSETH ON A11

What happened on Friday

The White House fired inspectors general of at least 12 major agencies in a purge that could clear the way for Trump loyalists.

Chicago school leaders said federal immigration agents showed up to an elementary school but were denied entry.

The Education Department said it was dismissing 17 complaints about book restrictions in schools.

The administration asked the Supreme Court to pause action in four cases, suggesting a shift in the government's legal position.

All right, all right, all right: Commanders give celebrity fans something to cheer for.



Candace Buckner
COLUMN

No metropolis cares less about bona fide celebrities than Washington. It's our source of pride, as well as our pathetic deficiency. This is a town that flaunts

its wealth, power and media clout, for sure, but good Lord, can we get something better than a Capital One Arena courtside sighting of NBC Washington meteorologist Doug Kammerer? And no offense to Virginia Del. Vivian Watts (D-Fairfax), but when she wore a red Capitals hat on the floor of the House of Delegates, it didn't quite send the internet into a tizzy the way Taylor Swift does when she shows up to cheer on her man and 'nem while wearing a custom



McConaughey



Henson

Chiefs puffer coat.

How can a city have such influence and yet be so lacking in star power? Why can't D.C. be the capital of pop culture like ... Kansas City? Fortunately, the Washington Commanders are here to fulfill all of our vacuous ambitions.

The Commanders — despite a quarter-century of nonsense — have actual, real-life celebrities in their fan base. Die-hard fans and not just weathermen or politicians

or Wolf Blitzer. The A- through C-listers who have endured name changes, quarterback carousels and the long, cold winter from 2009 to 2023. Some of them even faked smiles while hamming it up with Daniel Snyder. We call those "the real ones."

So if the Commanders pull off the impossible and go to the Super Bowl, an amazing thing will happen: There just might be a million close-ups of Matthew McConaughey, decked out in the hometown burgundy and gold, cheering from his suite inside the Superdome. Take that, Swifties. (And Kammerers.)

Here's a not-so-definitive list of the Commanders' biggest celebrity fans, ranked solely by their potential to make Washington look cool.

SEE COMMANDERS ON A18



JAH CHIKWENDU/THE WASHINGTON POST

It's all happening at the zoo

Pat Millius of Delaware — and many others — came to the National Zoo to see the pandas' debut on Friday. She joked that she would use her walker to "plow over" anyone in her way. **Story, B1**

IN THE NEWS

U.S. contractors in Gaza Armed American security workers will take up positions at checkpoints this weekend in the enclave, tasked with inspecting vehicles. **A11**

Church and state on the docket A case set for the Supreme Court may decide whether states can allow religious public education. **A18**

THE NATION
A \$100 billion AI project was in the works for months, but tech leaders praised only Trump. **A2**
Biden-era efforts to prosecute abortion clinic protest cases will be scaled back. **A3**

THE WORLD
In South Africa, a tragedy in an illicit mine has people demanding answers. **A9**
Palestinian prisoners freed as part of a cease-fire deal returned home to a hero's welcome. **A10**

THE ECONOMY
Meta's courting of Trump brought a backlash this week from users on Facebook and Instagram. **A13**
The president has pledged to cut rules, impose tariffs, overhaul energy and lower rates, but will those measures tackle inflation? **A14**

THE REGION
Thousands of antiabortion activists demonstrated at the Capitol during the annual March for Life. **B1**
A judge ordered Oath Keepers leader Stewart Rhodes to stay out of D.C., a ruling the city's interim U.S. attorney opposes. **B1**

STYLE
The intermission in the 215-minute-long film "The Brutalist" is a welcome relief for many moviegoers. **C1**
Marlee Matlin's Sundance documentary, with large swaths of silence, forces viewers to see things from her perspective. **C1**

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